

THE NATION'S PROTECTOR Gen. Asim Munir with Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif in Abbotabad, Apr. 26

PAKISTAN IS AWARE THAT MACRO-ECONOMIC STABILITY HAS RETURNED TO THE COUNTRY AFTER YEARS OF GREAT VOLATILITY. NOBODY WANTS TO TRADE THAT IN

unseriously. Some put it down to gallows humour, others to wit being the best defence against overblown rhetoric, yet others to annoyance at Indian analysts' lack of understanding of Pakistani realities. Someone suggested Pakistan needed to establish a "Tamgha-e-Memetiaz" for "outstanding bravery in the comment section and exceptional service to meme culture", a pun on the civilian Tamgha-e-Imtiaz (Medal of Distinction) award.

Of course, such frivolity is different from how Pakistan's government and establishment view matters. An indication of how seriously they took it came on April 29 when Pakistan information minister Atta Tarrar announced that Pakistan had "credible intelligence" that India was planning to "carry out military action against Pakistan in the next 24-36 hours". A day earlier, defence minister Khawaja Asif had indicated something similar, though he had backtracked after it started creating some panic.

There have been reminders sent out to the international media and governments that, with both Pakistan and India being nuclear powers, the costs of miscalculation and military escalation could be unimaginably high.

Pakistan has also stuck to its line that India has yet to provide any credible information connecting it to the Pahalgam attack. It has offered to participate in a "neutral" internationally-led investigation. Some ministers have dubbed the attack a "false flag" operation, implying that it was carried out by the Indian armed forces to provoke a crisis. Other analysts have connected it to the upcoming polls in Bihar, hinting that heightened tensions will be used by the ruling BJP to rally support.

Most Pakistanis have bought this, citing unanswered questions about how the attack took place in a heavily fortified area far away from the LoC and how the attackers managed to escape, the lack of familiarity with the group alleged to be behind the attack, and India's kneejerk blaming of Pakistan "within five minutes of the attack".

Among hardliners, or those willing to concede that it could be an attack by a local Kashmiri militant outfit, there is great scepticism around the Indian claims that this attack comes out of the blue. They point out that terrorism has been spiking for the past year in Balochistan and Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa, which Pakistan has tied to alleged backing from Indian covert operations.

In fact, in a press conference on April 29, the director-general of the armed forces Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), Lt Gen. Arshad Sharif Chaudhry, presented what he claimed was "incontrovertible proof" of Indian armed forces personnel—including a major—serving as handlers for terrorists arrested inside Pakistan. The Pakistan interior minister also pointed to alleged Indian involvement in the March 11 hijacking of the Jaffar Express train by Baloch militants, which resulted in 64 casualties.

Munir Emerges Stronger

Much of the Indian media seems to have focused on the allegedly fragile position of the army chief, Gen. Asim Munir. This is as far from the truth as it could get, and a poor reading of the structure of the Pakistan army. If anything, the drums of war beating across the border have strengthened his position. The threat of a potential Indian ingress into Pakistan has made the squabbling political opposition close ranks behind the establishment. While Imran Khan languishes in prison, his Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf has stated that it stands behind the armed forces in case of Indian aggression.

Any act of terrorism at this stage will likely be viewed as being backed by India, which will allow the establishment to go after them with a stronger hand. Pakistanis are aware that macro-economic stability has returned to the country after a couple of years of great volatility. Nobody wants to trade that in.

Most Pakistanis are amenable to building better relations with India, as long as India is willing to engage sincerely and subtantively. But when they see cricket teams being stopped from touring, threats of waters being diverted and calls for Pakistan's dismemberment on Indian media, they do not evoke ideas of friendship or sincerity. Hubris and bullying tactics will not be the way forward. ■